

TAMBARAM

Chromepet » Pallavaram » Tambaram West » Rajakilpakkam » Mannivakkam » Guindy » Keelkattalai » Nanganallur » Guduvanchery » Hasthinapuram » Pammal » Tambaram East

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Finally, a pedestrian signal along MIT flyover

V. SANTHANAM

A pedestrian crossing traffic signal has been facilitated along Madras Institute of Technology (MIT) Flyover - Grade Separator on GST Road in Chromepet. This comes as a huge relief to pedestrians, who previously risked crossing the stretch.

For many years, People's Awareness Association, Chromepet, and Chromepet New Colony Residents' Welfare Association had been requesting Greater Chennai Traffic Police and the traffic wing of the Tambaram City Police Commissionerate to install a signal to enable pedestrians to cross GST Road safely.

A good number of pedestrians, including students at MIT, people working in companies along GST Road, including at Ma-



hindra World City, Chettipuniyam, and even in the Oragadam region (on the lane towards Chengalpattu), board the staff buses at MIT haltover.

We have requested that the

traffic police post personnel to help people cross the road and regulate traffic.

V. Santhanam is a social activist and a resident of Chromepet

Seen in Sholinganallur



On May 23, father-son birding duo and members of Madras Naturalists Society, R.V. Ramanan and Shreyas Ramanan spotted a Slaty-breasted rail at Perumbakkam wetland, also known as the Sholinganallur marshland. This patch is part of the Pallikaranai marsh. PHOTO: SHREYAS RAMANAN

'Facilitate a digital clock for the visually challenged'

P. SATHYANARAYANAN

Southern Railway should have a digital clock announcement system at the Guindy railway station footbridge to benefit the visually challenged.

People can be seen asking the public for the time, and this facility will help them plan and start their journey to their destination earlier.

Apart from this, at present, the Southern Railway has put up signboards for platforms 1 and 2 at the

footbridge, but they are not helpful to commuters.

The commuters, who are relatively new to the terminal, ask their counterparts which platforms to go to board the electric trains towards Chennai Beach, Tambaram, Chengalpattu, and Thirumalpur.

The announcements can be made through the system, or the platform number can be denoted on the tickets.

P. Sathyanarayanan is a senior social activist and a long-time resident of Guindy

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Photo used for representational purpose

Relocate the foot overbridge at Karapakkam on OMR

At present, this pedestrian facility is located at a point that is strikingly distant from the bus stop on both sides of Old Mahabalipuram Road in Karapakkam

CAROL M

The foot overbridge near Apollo Cradle at Karapakkam on Old Mahabalipuram Road is located at a point that is distant from the bus stop on both sides of the road.

To get to either of the two bus stops, the bus commuter has to

take a long walk. A U-turn has opened opposite Chettinad Hospital which makes crossing ideal but highly risky. This crossing is not managed nor does it have a pedestrian crossing feature.

Pedestrians and motorists choosing to cross over must compete with oncoming traffic risking life and limb. At night it is highly

dangerous as on both sides oncoming traffic do not slow down facilitate pedestrian movement. If the foot overbridge is brought closer to the area between Prestige Cyber Towers and Chettinad Hospital, it would not only help pedestrians immensely but also minimise the risk of road-crossing accidents on this section.

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Residents of Thiruvengadapuram list out a host of concerns about this green space which was opened two years ago



Snapshots of the park. PHOTOS: T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Squalor reigns at park in Vengambakkam

T.S. ATUL SWAMINATHAN

Residents of Thiruvengadapuram in Vengambakkam Village have requested the Agaramthen Village Panchayat to take steps to maintain a park in the locality.

Constructed at a cost of more than ₹20 lakh and spread across 10,000 square feet, with funds from the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority, the park on Fifth Street is in a deplorable state. No maintenance work has been carried out in the last two years.

One can spot greenery on the

walker's path. The plants in the garden have withered away. The park lacks garbage bins and trash is strewn around.

At night, the park is misused by tipplers. The electrical equipment in the lighting poles is exposed and poses a safety hazard. The merry-go-round is rusty and a risk to children, residents complained.

A. R. Lakshmanan, a resident of Thiruvengadapuram, says, "Visitors have to walk on the available walking space. The area along the children's area is overrun with grass."

The park, which became publicly accessible more than two years ago, is open day and night but lacks a security guard.



After the rains, the park has stagnant water and is a breeding ground for mosquitoes, residents say.

There is no stormwater drainage network to carry rainwater to Agaramthen Lake. Agaramthen Village Panchayat has laid a path along the

gate and installed large, round pipes beneath the stretch to drain rainwater into a vacant plot, Lakshmanan added.

Besides, a parking area should be facilitated; the area outside the park, which is littered with construction debris, should be le-



velled. Even the vegetation should be weeded out.

"I have taken up the issue with the Panchayat to clean up the trash, weed the vegetation, and carry out the requisite maintenance work, but no action is forthcoming," adds Lakshmanan.

'Shift this dump yard out of Vengambakkam'

V. SAMPATH

On Vengambakkam-Mappedu Road in Vengambakkam, there is a dumping yard adjoining a cemetery for years. Tons of garbage are dumped here day in and day out. This is an eyesore. Bad odour emanates from the garbage. It is a real health hazard. It is unclear whether this matter has been brought to the attention of the authorities concerned at any time in the past for redressal.

The dump yard has encroached upon the cemetery to the extent that, for practical purposes, the cemetery is non-existent.

Yet another matter that needs to be delved into is that dozens of buf-



The trash yard along Mappedu-Vengambakkam Road in Vengambakkam. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

faloes, cows, and dogs can be seen browsing on garbage at any time, day or night.

It is not healthy for the cattle, as they rummage through the garbage and gobble whatever they can get. It is a matter of serious environmental concern. The owners are to blame. These cows and buffaloes are indeed no stray animals. They have their rightful owners. The thing is the owners seldom care for their domestic animals, given the cost, effort and upkeep involved. The dumping yard also prevents the drainage of floodwaters. It will prove dangerous when it rains heavily in this area during the monsoon, flooding all the adjoining residential areas.

V. Sampath is a resident of Vengambakkam



T. ARVIND

After years of remaining locked and largely unused, the pedestrian subway near Tambaram railway station is set for a revamp, with the Tambaram Corporation initiating a major clean-up drive ahead of a proposed ₹4-crore redevelopment project.

The subway, inaugurated in 2018, below the Tambaram flyover to connect GST Road and Velachery Main Road had fallen into disuse owing to poor maintenance, safety concerns and alleged structural issues. Activists and commuters had repeatedly urged authorities to reopen and maintain the facility.

On May 27, Tambaram MLA and Minister for Human Resources Management, D. Sarathkumar, along with the Chengalpattu Collector, inspected the cleaning works being undertaken around the subway under the “Clean & Green Tambaram” programme, and reviewed safety measures.

Tambaram Corporation Commissioner S. Balachandran said the civic body planned to redevelop the eastern side of the subway with food courts and recreational facilities.

“Model designs are ready and the project is likely to be completed in a few months after obtaining the necessary clearances,” he said.

Maintenance concerns

According to a senior Southern Railway official, the subway was handed over to the State government after construction was completed in 2018 and, as per the memorandum of understanding, maintenance responsibility rested with the Corporation.

“Only issues related to electrical works were brought to the notice of the Railways, and those were rectified,” the official said, adding

Unused subway set for revamp

Civic body plans food courts, recreational facilities around subway that remained locked for years



(From top) The locked pedestrian subway near Tambaram railway station on May 23; workers engaged in cleaning and levelling operations on May 27; and a model design released by the Tambaram Corporation for the proposed redevelopment of the eastern side of the subway with food courts and recreational facilities. PHOTOS: T. ARVIND AND SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



that the Corporation was currently in full control of the facility's upkeep.

However, uncertainty remains over the ownership and maintenance responsibility of the ap-

proach road on the eastern side of the subway.

K. Ramesh, president of the MES Road Ganapathipuram Welfare Association, said commuters did not patronise the subway be-

cause of its slightly deviated alignment and alleged structural shortcomings.

“Due to lack of security, school and college students avoided using it,” he said. He added that the sub-

way remained shut for long periods after the COVID-19 pandemic as a precautionary measure.

Anti-social activities

Following protests by residents and activists including members of People's Awareness Forum, the subway was reopened in 2023 after electrical defects were rectified. However, poor maintenance again led to declining public use.

Residents alleged the neglected premises later became a hub for anti-social activities, drug abuse and other illicit activities.

Prakash, an autorickshaw driver from a nearby stand, said the subway could have attracted more users if the access had been aligned towards Market Road or Shanmugham Road.

“Now, it takes a deviated route and ends in an area with minimal public utility,” he said.

He suggested relocating pavement vendors from Shanmugham Road to the eastern side of the subway to improve activity and security in the area.

Balachandran said the Corporation had requested the Railways to hand over the approach road to facilitate the proposed redevelopment.

“Once the approach road is handed over, it will give impetus to our plans to develop the surroundings into a recreational and food hub that can attract residents both in the mornings and evenings,” he said. Activists, however, stressed that merely reopening or revamping the subway would not be sufficient.

Ramesh said the approach roads should be properly relaid to prevent inundation during rain and dedicated security personnel should be deployed on both the GST Road side and the eastern side to prevent anti-social activities.

“Only then will students from several nearby schools be able to use the subway safely,” he added.

Desilting work begins at Chitlapakkam Lake

The residents welfare associations from Chitlapakkam Anna Nagar West, Chitlapakkam Muthulakshmi Nagar and Sri Sarvamangala Nagar discussed long-pending demands

The area along Periyar Nagar, East Tambaram - Tambaram Sanatorium, and the western side bunds of Chitlapakkam Lake, which was an eyesore with waste water and trash engulfing the lake, will be a thing of the past.

On May 27, K. Balachander, Commissioner, Tambaram City Municipal Corporation, and D. Sarath Kumar, MLA of the Tambaram Assembly constituency and Minister for Human Resources Management and Ex-Servicemen Welfare (portfolios), visited the lake to inaugurate desilting work.

S. Chandrasekaran, secretary of Chitlapakkam Anna Nagar (West) Residents Welfare Association, L. Sundararaman, president of Chitlapakkam Muthulakshmi Nagar Welfare Association (CMNWA), and P. Venkatraman, president of Sri Sarvamangala Nagar Residents Association (SSMNRA), met Sarath Kumar and listed a charter of demands.

L. Sundararaman said the Water Resources Department should construct a concrete canal to divert water to the collection well at the



Tambaram MLA D. Sarath Kumar plants a sapling on the bund of Chitlapakkam lake.
PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

lake's southern end (East Tambaram region), and from there to a sewage treatment plant in the region.

Underground drainage network
The State Government should commence and complete the construction of the network in the Chitla-

pakkam and the adjacent areas.

L. Sundararaman says, "The previous Tamil Nadu government had allocated more than ₹ 1000 crore for the project, and a detailed project report has been approved. The newly formed government should complete the project to restore waterbodies."

S. Chandrasekaran urged Sarath Kumar to regularise the lake inlet channel to receive rainwater from Pachaimalai, Tambaram Sanatorium. He also urged Sarath to facilitate a 360-degree connectivity at the lake.

Drinking water

At present, residents receive drinking water from the Palar River basin once every 10 to 15 days, says R. M. Easwaran, treasurer of CMNWA.

"The water should be supplied once every two to three days with a capacity of 150 liters per person.

After years of requests to the State Government to include the region in the Chembarambakkam Drinking Water Scheme, the previous State Government instead included in the Nemmeli Seawater Desalination Plant drinking water scheme.

"The State government should expedite this scheme and ensure drinking water supply to the residents of Chitlapakkam and surrounding areas," says Easwaran.

The Commissioner said arrangements are being made to obtain the required water from the Nemmeli desalination plant, and regular supply will be made within days.

P. Venkatraman urged the MLA to visit Sembakkam Lake and restore the sprawling waterbody.

Other demands include the introduction of bus services from the Chitlapakkam bus terminus to Saidapet, Mudichur and Kilambakkam regions.

Text: T.S. Atul Swaminathan

Environment Day event at lake

As part of World Environment Day celebrations, Saving Nanmangalam Lake Team (SNLT) in co-ordination with NGO Thuvakkam is organising drawing, colouring, and painting activities on June 6.

The activities will be held on a 3,000-square-foot wall opposite the Nanmangalam lake from 3 p.m. to 6.30 p.m.

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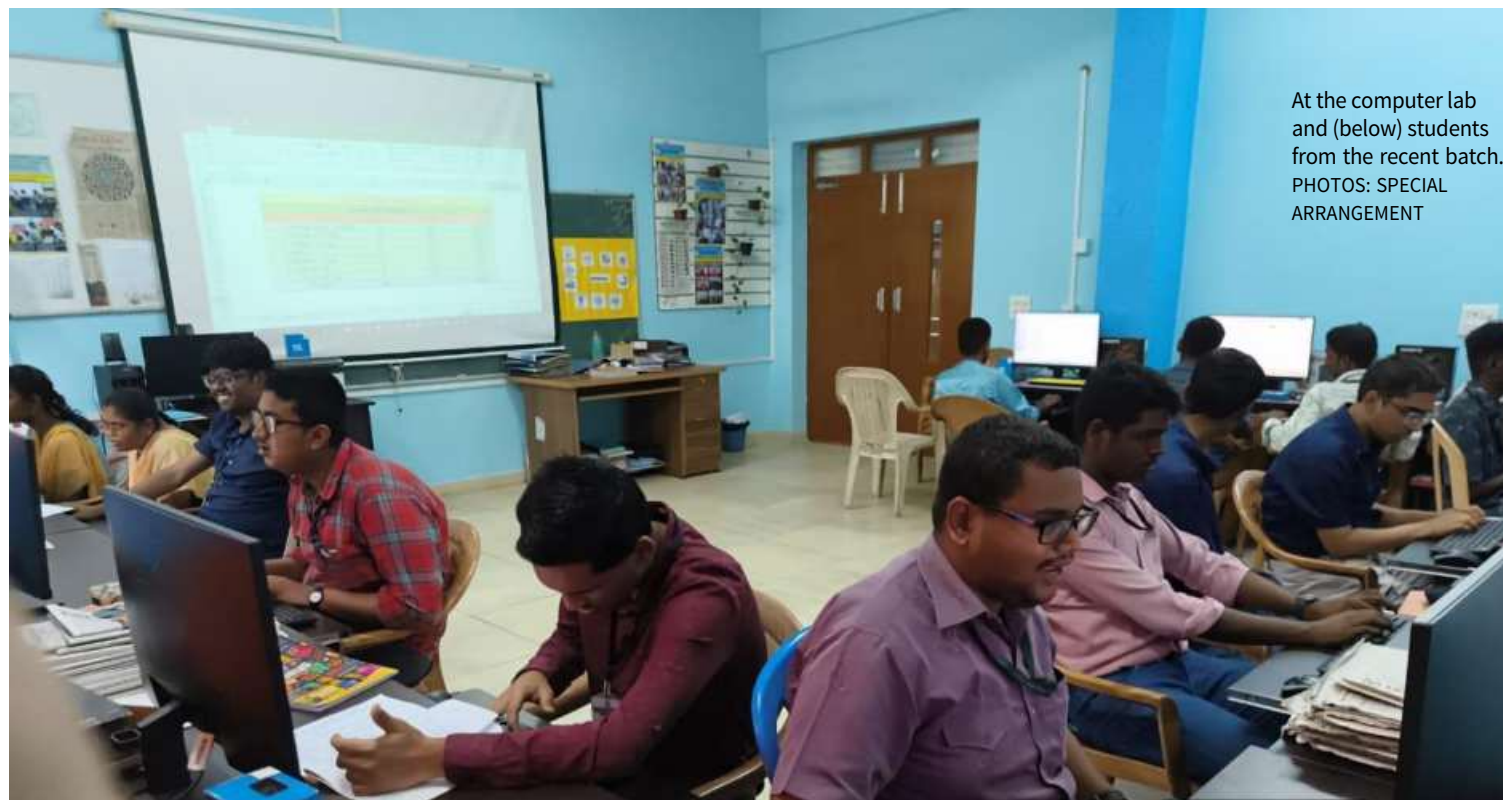
Entrepreneurial skill training in solar energy

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute is conducting a training programme on entrepreneurial skills necessary in the solar energy sector. It will be held from June 3 to 12. According to a press release, the programme will focus on basics of solar energy, solar components and system design. The institute is also conducting another workshop on baking from June 2 to 5. Those from 18 to 55 years of age with a minimum educational qualification of class 10 can apply. The workshops will be held at the institute's premises at EDII Office Road, SIDCO Industrial Estate, Guindy. For details, call 8668102600 / 78069 18309.

Mini dumps in Pozhichalur



On Cowl Bazaar Road in Pozhichalur, the walkway has been littered with garbage, turning it into a mini trash yard. Further, along the residential houses, vacant plots are used as dumping grounds, creating a breeding ground for mosquitoes, and contaminating the groundwater, forcing the residents to buy water cans for cooking and drinking. PHOTOS: B. VELANKANNI RAJ



At the computer lab and (below) students from the recent batch.
PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Quick facts

Course: Diploma in Office Automation and Assistive Technology for PwD affiliated with Bharathidasan University

Minimum qualification: SSLC certificate

Who can join: Individuals with Intellectual Disabilities, Autism Spectrum Disorder, Mental Illness, Specific Learning Disabilities, and Multiple Disabilities

Content: Digital literacy, office automation, and exposure to assistive technologies.

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LIFY THOMAS

They are diploma holders and it is a diploma like no other. It imparts training in office automation and assistive technology, but also seeks to put the students in command of their lives. The fifteen students who completed the one-year programme successfully also learnt how to socialise with peers, be independent, besides other social skills.

Diploma in Office Automation and Assistive Technology, as it is called, is offered by National Institute for Empowerment of Persons with Multiple Disabilities (NIEPMD) in Muttukadu. Affiliated with Bharathidasan University in Tiruchirappalli, the two-semester diploma programme is all set to have its fourth batch.

It is designed for those wired differently, blessed with different abilities. Among the 15 graduates, some have intellectual disabilities, some have multiple disabilities and a few are on the autism spectrum. Their abilities outshine their disabilities. At the farewell function held recently on the NIEPMD campus, no one was in any doubt about that. It was a moment to cherish for their parents and teachers.

There is a massive sense of achievement for parents of Suraag Sanjay K, and it comes from the fact that during the course of this diploma programme, he got used to travelling independently. For the first month, from his home in Ambattur to Muttukadu, Suraag, who has intellectual disability, and his father K.G. Sanjay would travel together. His father would drop him and wait at the campus till he finished classes in the evening. A gentle nudge from the faculty got the father-duo to effect a change in that routine. Today, Suraag travels on his own both ways; only on the

Equipped for office, empowered for life

The one-year diploma programme offered by NIEPMD in association with Bharathidasan University strikes a commendable balance between technical and soft skills



home stretch, the last mile, the father picks up the son.

Suraag's classmate Darshan, who has intellectual disability, started travelling by bus while pursuing Class XII. His father L. Gopi raised the bar during in the last one year making him travel by different bus routes. "For instance, during the Chennai Book Fair I dropped him one way and showed him the stop from where he could take his return journey. Another big change I saw in him is the ability to handle situations and also knowing what

to speak when," says Gopi, who works at a private firm.

Skills pertaining to financial literacy, communication and interpersonal dynamics got strengthened through structured group activities, helping the students engage more effectively with peers and instructors. The curriculum also reinforced punctuality, discipline and teamwork, say parents of the students. Besides a host of outdoor activities on the sprawling campus, a faculty from Tamil Nadu Dr. J. Jayalalitha Music and Fine Arts Un-

iversity visits the campus to offer music classes.

The computer lab for DOATT programme was set up with the sponsorship of Geetha Bhavan Trust which also developed a recreation lab for the students.

K. Balabaskar, Lecturer - Department of Adult Independent Learning, NIEPMD, says this inclusive, credit-based higher education programme is one of its kind in India.

"This is a college exclusive for those with special needs where we train them for a year in both techni-

cal know-how and essential life skills to equip them in all respects to take up higher studies or join the workplace," says Balabaskar.

Parents of children with disabilities spend a lot on therapy. "At NIEPMD, it is available within the campus along with a host of other facilities like psychomotor activity that they can avail," says Balabaskar, adding that B. Nithya Prabha, Lecturer and R. Rajesh Kanna, Clinical Assistant are also part of the team.

The one-month internship was another way to sensitise students to the demands of the workplace. Institutions such as Ragas Dental College, TamilNadu JJ. Fisheries University, Karna Vidya Foundation, Anna Centenary Library, MEPZ - Tambaram, Armoured Vehicles Nigam Limited in Avadi and even a neighbourhood stationery shop were on board offering internships to students with disabilities.

M. Prabavathy, associate professor, Centre for Differently Abled Persons, Bharathidasan University, says the University has been offering a number of courses for those with special needs since 2011 and NIEPMD requested them to extend this effort to benefit a large section of students.

Under this MoU, Bharathidasan University designs the course, conducts exams and rewards certificates. NIEPMD is the implementing partner. (Bachelor of computer application for speech and hearing impaired, photo editing and 2D animation course for autism are among courses the University offers).

Prabavathy says these are courses where the outcome is more important than considerations such as how many students are enrolled. "Special students need individualised attention as the learning needs are unique for each of them. These courses are aimed at making them independent, both financially and personally," says Prabavathy.

Course coordinators say that some have gone in for higher studies in regular colleges, some have joined the Job Coaching Scheme for TNPSC examination and many have joined the workplace.

A clean footpath will draw pedestrians



The image shows a section of the footpath at Sixth Main Road, near Fourth Main Road in Nanganallur, which was barricaded with steel railings. While this measure is aimed at preventing vehicles from parking on the footpath, it has not helped in a big way. This stretch is near a market area, where vehicles are parked on the carriageway and on the pavement. As the entry to the footpath is not kept clean, pedestrians avoid walking on it. Zone XII (Alandur) officials must clean the footpath area for people to walk on it.



TN Nature Food Producers Federation meets Governor

Senthilkumar Maruthamuthu, state coordinator of the Tamil Nadu Nature Food Producers Federation and Chairman of Cholanadu Farmers Producers Company Ltd, called on Governor Rajendra Vishwanath Arlekar at Raj Bhavan recently. Senthilkumar presented a brief on the agro-ecological transformations led by the Federation, with a special focus on the Cauvery Delta. He highlighted how modern IT enterprise workflows are being synchronised with ancient Tamil wisdom to drive rural prosperity, scale native seed conservation and protect regional biodiversity, said a release.



WOW Cricket League ends on a high

RVS College of Arts and Science served as the title sponsor of WOW Cricket League (WCL) Season 2.

The tournament, organised by WOW HR at the Jeppiaar Engineering College ground, drew enthusiastic participation from the corporate community.

K. Senthil Ganesh, managing trustee of RVS Educational Institutions, inaugurated the tournament.

The tournament featured nine corpo-

rate teams competing in 12 exciting matches, culminating in the crowning of a champion team.

According to a press release, the tournament served as a vibrant platform for networking, team building, and development of meaningful business relationships. WCL is designed to promote employee engagement and corporate networking through the unifying spirit of sports, added the release.

Cricket academy completes 35th summer coaching camp

The 35th Summer Coaching Camp conducted by Asiatic Cricket Academy, present in the Pallavaram-Chromepet area, concluded recently after providing young cricketers with training and match exposure, says a press release.

The camp started intensive training sessions from May 1, with participants displaying keen interest and dedication under the guidance of the academy's experienced coaches.

Training began each day at 5.55 a.m. The academy expressed its gratitude to parents who motivated their children to wake up early and ensured their punctual arrival at the ground.

Following special drills and stretching exercises, the trainees enthusiastically participated in the coaching sessions aimed at enhancing their batting, bowling and fielding skills, says the press

release. During the summer, the academy's boys participated in various tournaments organised by cricket academies in and around Chennai. Among the notable performances were centuries scored by Akhil and Pranav, while several bowlers also delivered outstanding spells in competitive matches.

The release highlights the efforts by Prabhu, who took special initiative to ensure that the boys gained valuable match exposure by participating in numerous tournaments and fixtures.

In all, the trainees played 35 matches across various age categories during the camp. The academy thanked markers Cheeni and Arun for their assistance. Special appreciation was extended to Dr. Geetha Ashwin Kumar for donating a first-aid kit and to Chrome Sports for its support in the successful conduct of the camp, the release adds.

Workshop on making incense sticks

Tamil Nadu Agricultural University Information & Training Centre is conducting a culinary workshop on making flavour powders from spices on June 4. According to a press release, the session will focus on powders meant for vegetarian and non-vegetarian cuisines. Another workshop on making incense sticks and camphors will be held on June 5. Both the sessions will be held at the centre's premises at Agro Tech Green Park, Thiru. Vi. Ka. Industrial Estate, Guindy. Call 044 - 29530048



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The death of this Green sea turtle near Akkarai beach a few days ago should serve as a reminder of what we can do to make the Chennai coast truly home for the sea turtles, particularly the Olive Ridley turtles

PRINCE FREDERICK

Here are the details of a recent event by the southern coast of Chennai. A few days ago, Captain A. Ranganathan, a compelling voice in aviation circles and a resident of Injambakkam on the sea-side, chanced by a Green sea turtle that was dead to everything around it. The sad sighting happened on the sands between Akkarai beach and Injambakkam beach. Every event has a lesson: some lessons might not be actionable. What is the lesson, actionable or otherwise, to take away from this?

As a hatchling, this green sea turtle would have dodged a cartel of pelagic predators. As an adult, it would have survived attacks by apex marine predators. All of that for what? Only to be done in by a ridiculous piece of nylon. That is irony of an order where pathos and farcicality exist side by side.

Net loss



A dead Green sea turtle near Akkarai beach.
PHOTO: CAPTAIN A. RANGANATHAN

An inference: danger is often most potent where it is least suspected. A seemingly innocuous civic infra work on the road outside your gates does not get your antennas up;

and you get impaled on steel rods jutting out of an open trench. A fishing net does not get your flippers twitch with anxiety; and you get entangled and find a tragic end. While

that inference could be right, it puts an undue burden on the victim, letting the perpetrator off the hook. Where danger is not expected but hidden and real, those alive to the possibility should take preventive action.

This topic is hardly new: what can be done in the coastal waters to protect sea turtles?

Arun V., coordinator of Students Sea Turtle Conservation Network notes that from the government side, considerable efforts have been taken, largely by way of patrolling to check illegal fishing methods that can result in death of sea turtles.

Despite that, the deaths continue. "Sea turtle deaths in the last two years (actually last two seasons) have been alarming. In relative terms, the deaths have been low in 2026, but that does mean much when you compare it against the huge numbers in 2025."

When Arun is talking about the season, he is essentially talking about the Olive Ridley nesting along the Chennai coast, the nesting happening from January to March, and the hatchlings leaving for the seas in April.

"We do not get Green sea turtles often but Olive Ridley turtles getting entangled in fishing nets is way too common," says Arun. "Those the maximum traffic is around the season, those three to four months of the year, turtle movement is found throughout the year."

Arun notes that one measure, which ought to be definitely taken during the Olive Ridley turtle hatchling season is to avoid laying out the

fishing nets in the waters at night, as it is only at night these turtles come ashore to lay eggs. The possibility of entanglement in nets laid in the coastal waters is high at night during the nesting season. During a recent interaction with fishermen from Nainar Kuppam, this reporter was presented with many cases of how fishermen disentangled sea turtles from fishing nets and eased them back into the waters, safely. Fishing communities along the coast revere sea turtles attaching metaphysical significance to them.

"There is never wanton killing; it is always accidental," says Arun.

The SSTCN coordinator observes that sustainable fishing practices would be a blanket solution, but set against the question of livelihoods for fishing communities, they cannot be activated at will. The best bet would be educate fishing communities how to take certain steps, those factoring in the seasons to prevent turtle deaths from entanglement in nets and injuries from boats. Meanwhile, there are a few things residents of neighbourhoods along the Chennai coast could do for their part to help the cause. Arun lists them out: "Steer clear of misinformation: the biggest challenge this year came from wrong information put out on social media. As a result, many people were disturbing the nesting Olive Ridley turtles with bright lights right on their faces. Turtles abandoned nesting. What residents can do: avoid lights, littering and vehicles on beaches. Corporation should switch off mast lights during the hatchling season."

Making the right moves at

Meet coach and counsellor Ebenezer Joseph who recently won three gold medals in the 60+ category at the Commonwealth Chess Championships

K. KEERTHIVASAN

At 60, Ebenezer Joseph is a bundle of energy. He coaches children, trains teachers, competes in tournaments and also serves as counsellor for educational institutions, strongly advocating the inclusion of chess in school curricula.

Recently, the Anna Nagar resident, who works as an Audit Supervisor in the Indian Audit & Ac-

counts Department (IA & AD) at the Finance and Audit Office in Egmore, made headlines after winning three gold medals in the classical, rapid and blitz events in the 60+ category at the Commonwealth Chess Championships held in Kalutara, Sri Lanka.

Ebenezer was thrilled with the achievement, especially since he had only hoped to return with at least a bronze medal. "I expected to win one bronze medal, but to win three gold medals was unbelievable. Though I won in the 60+ category, I played in the Open sec-



Ebenezer Joseph (second from left) felicitated by Aadhav Arjuna, MLA, Villivakkam and other dignitaries

tion alongside top young Grandmasters such as P. Iniyar and S. Rohith Krishna, besides FIDE Master Sakline Mostafa Sajid, Candidate Master S. Sivathanujan and Woman Candidate Master Ananya Raman. It felt great," he said.

Speaking about the demands of competing in three formats, which often meant spending long hours at the board, Ebenezer said the tournament was physically and mentally exhausting. "The pressure was immense because on certain days we had to play as many as eight rounds.

My matches started at 4 p.m. and finished at 8 p.m., so much so that on the last day I hardly knew what was happening on the board!" he said with a smile.

Having spent more than 34 years with the Indian Audit & Accounts Department, Ebenezer felt the process of obtaining a No Objection Certificate (NOC) from employers to participate in international tournaments should be simplified. "When a player is representing the country, the process of getting an NOC from the employer to take part in an inter-

national event should be made easier," he said.

Ebenezer continues to balance his professional commitments with his passion for chess and social service. "I will continue playing, continue trying to help more sportspeople get recruited into Government offices and continue working with tribal communities," said the 60-year-old, who is also a Senior Lead Instructor for FIDE Chess in Education Commission and is set to retire from IA & AD in November this year.

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